R

Released last week, Anubhav Sinha's action thriller, *Anek*, sees Ayushmann Khurrana play an undercover officer on a mission in the Northeast. (The state is unspecified.) During the course of two and a half hours, he begins to question the political strategy of his masters, the Indian government. *Anek* comes at a time when audiences seem to prefer larger-than-life heroes, men with much machismo. Three of the biggest pan-India hits of the past six months—*Pushpa*, *RRR* and *KGF: Chapter 2*—all seem to prove this assumption. Khurrana, though, has made a career out of playing heroes who are fallible, insecure and oftentimes not very likeable. The actor, for his part, isn't too fazed by the current box office trend. He tells us, "Mass cinema will never go out of fashion. Every genre has to survive. People do not want reality every single time. They want to escape from it also."



AYUSHMANN KHURRANA in a still from Anubhav Sinha's action thriller Anek

Looking at the film choices he has made over his decade-long career, it seems clear that Khurrana has arrived at a formula that ensures both survival and success in a highly competitive Hindi film industry. While he will sometimes play to the gallery with a film like *Dream Girl* (2019), he will often stick to what he calls his "staple genre", the social comedy—*Shubh Mangal Savdhan* (2017), *Shubh Mangal Zyada Savdhan* (2020), *Badhaai Ho* (2018), *Bala* (2019) and *Chandigarh Kare Aashiqui* (2021). *Anek* is Khurrana's attempt at doing "cinema for change". He says, "If you have a certain voice as a director or an actor, it should reflect through your art. If you want to say something, say it through your art."

Having started off with street theatre in his Chandigarh college, Khurrana is today more watchful than zealous. He says, "You will fall flat on your face if you have to comment on every single issue that you have next to no idea about." Though he is "very non-confrontational as a person", he adds he is "confrontational" as an artist. "There's a dichotomy there," he says. "I don't want to be making news with controversy." By collaborating with Anubhav Sinha—director of several hard-hitting films like *Mulk* (2018), *Article 15* (2019) and *Thappad* (2020)—Khurrana gets handed an opportunity to showcase his "confrontational" side. He says, "*Anek* is an intelligent film. The narrative is complex. It deals with the deep politics of the Northeast, so it cannot be your typical potboiler. I get the courage to do a film like this only after doing films like *Dream Girl* and *Bala*. I have to strike that balance."

It is clear that *Anek* will not be one of Khurrana's highest grossers. That milestone will for now still belong to *Dream Girl*, an all-out entertainer which had grossed Rs 139 crore nationwide. Unlike *Article 15*, the last Sinha-Khurrana collaboration, *Anek* can be seen struggling hard to keep audiences invested in its cause and its characters. In his attempt to incorporate the many issues that plague the Northeast—insurgency, drug addiction, neglect from the mainland, racial abuse—Sinha bites more than he can chew. The film crumbles under the weight of questions like 'who is an Indian?' What we get is a convoluted drama with a lot of